ʿIrfan: A Journey into Islamic Mysticism

An Introduction for Seekers

Based on a lecture series by
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An invitation

وَأَنِرْ أَبْصَارَ قُلُوبِنَا بِضِيَاءِ نَظَرِهَا إِلَيْكَ حَتَّىٰ تَخْرِقَ أَبْصَارُ الْقُلُوبِ حُجُبَ النُّورِ فَتَصِلَ إِلَىٰ مَعْدِنِ الْعَظَمَةِ

Enlighten the eyes of our hearts with the light of their looking at You to the extent that they penetrate the veils of light and reach the Source of Grandeur.[1]

Munajat Sha'baniyyah

What is 'irfan?

These words come from the Munajat Sha'baniyyah, a prayer many of us recite in the month of Sha'ban. The line asks God to light up the eyes of our hearts with the light of looking at Him, until those eyes pass through even the veils of light and reach the source of His grandeur. It is a request to see God with the heart and to be near Him. Requests like this one were written for us, by the Imams (as), as an endeavour for the ordinary believer.

Despite saying these words in our munajats and on auspicious occasions, we find that seeking to know God does not feature in our day-to-day routine. Praying, fasting, and paying what is due, the *wajibat*, are the dominant undertaking, and they are what most of us mean by practising the religion. The other side, the one the Munajat describes, in which the believer seeks to know God and to come near Him, is often less practised. That side of the religion is called *'irfan*.

[1] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165.

ʿIrfan is the Arabic name for what English books call Islamic mysticism, and the two words do not say the same thing. "Mysticism" suggests mystery, something hidden and hard to pin down. The Arabic word names a kind of knowing. It shares its root with *maʿrifah*, knowledge, and an *ʿarif* is, in Sheikh Bahmanpour's words, "someone who knows".

The knowing meant here is not information about God. It is knowing Him from close, with the heart, which is what the Munajat asks for. In Murtada Mutahhari's words, the ʿarif "wishes to reach the very kernel and reality of existence, God, to become connected to it and witness it"[2]. ʿIrfan is that witnessing, and the training of the soul to reach that reality. It is part of the Islam we already know: its sources are the teachings of the Qur'an, the Prophet ﷺ, and the Imams (as) from his Ahl al-Bayt, and the prayer at the head of this page is one of them.

This book is predicated on the belief that every follower of Islam should find ʿirfan a worthwhile pursuit. ʿIrfan travels through the self and never leaves the shariʿa. It is walked by a tested and ordered method. It is rooted in the teachings of the Qur'an, the Prophet ﷺ, and the Imams from his Ahl al-Bayt. And it ends not in withdrawal from the world but in return: to people, with God, and to God Himself.

Who this book is for

The argument is addressed to anyone who prays, fasts, and recites the duʿas, and who has wondered whether there is more to these acts than getting them right; whether the religion has another dimension. No knowledge of ʿirfan, of philosophy, or of Arabic is assumed. This book strives for brevity and clarity in its role as a welcoming guide to beginning the journey towards ʿirfan. Each chapter opens with a section that details some of the words you'll meet, along with an explanation, and all terms are gathered in the glossary at the end. Additional call-out sections are spread throughout with helpful context and short side notes.

[2]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 12.

How the book is built

The book is built in five parts. Each answers one question and depends on the one before.

Part One, *The Call* (Chapters One to Three), asks why a believer should bother. It answers that the Qur'an invites more than the minimum: not only knowing about God, but knowing Him. The goal of ʿirfan is already on our lips in our duʿas.

Part Two, *Getting Ready* (Chapters Four to Seven), describes the landscape a traveller passes through on the journey towards ʿirfan: the self. It also positions the shariʿa as the boundary that keeps the traveller safe, and the guide as the one who walks alongside them.

Part Three, *The Road* (Chapters Eight to Twelve), asks how the path is walked: along the sequence of stages, from repentance through to discipline, love, and finally the loss of the false self.

Part Four, *Fellow Travellers* (Chapters Thirteen to Fifteen), meets those who walked the road before us. It shows the road's roots in the teachings of the Qur'an, the Prophet ﷺ, and the Imams from his Ahl al-Bayt; where its travellers arrived; and how Shia ʿirfan relates to Sufism.

Part Five, *The Destination* (Chapters Sixteen and Seventeen), asks what the voyage is for, with its answer lying in what the traveller brings back: the friends of God return to serve their people, but now with God unveiled in their hearts. Chapter Seventeen then follows every soul on its own return to God.

Where this book comes from

This book is inspired by a lecture series on Islamic mysticism given by Sheikh M. S. Bahmanpour. The content and structure of those lectures are the core of the book. Wherever the Sheikh is quoted directly, the words are his own and come from his series.

Turning spoken lectures into a book has called for some editorial adaptation. To suit a wider readership, the book also adds context and explanation to support its main arguments. It also draws on the wider literature, from the words of the Imams in Nahj al-Balagha, al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya, and the Mafatih, to the great Shia scholars from across the ages. They range from

Sayyid Haydar Amuli in the fourteenth century and Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi at the turn of the twentieth, to modern scholars such as the esteemed ʿAllama Tabataba'i, Imam Khomeini, and Ayatullah Mutahhari. Every source is given in a footnote, for readers who want to go further.

The finer questions of ʿirfan remain an ongoing conversation among our *ʿulama'*: whether a seeker needs a guide from the first step, how much solitude is wise, and how far ordinary believers can travel. Where they differ, this book presents each view with neutrality.

What you can expect

Three guiding principles frame the discussions in the chapters that follow. The first concerns attempts to gain powers such as mind reading or seeing into the future, which is a folly not associated with a genuine pursuit of ʿirfan. As Chapter One shows, Sheikh Bahmanpour and the wider literature both hold to this principle.

The second is that there is no separate sect or order through which ʿirfan must be gained. Shia ʿirfan has no institution of authority beside the Imam. How this position differs from that of the Sufi orders is explored in Chapter Fifteen.

The third principle is the most important: no part of the journey towards ʿirfan requires stepping outside the shariʿa, and nothing on that journey is gained by doing so. The beginning of ʿirfan, as the Sheikh puts it, is the shariʿa. Far from going around the law or rising above it, the inner path is in fact the law lived from the inside. Nothing in this book asks a reader to set aside the rulings of the jurists or the guidance of their marjaʿ. A fear that mysticism might do exactly that is the primary reason some scholars have been wary of ʿirfan. Chapter Fourteen sets out their wider concerns and the answers given to them.

By the end, a reader should feel able to say what ʿirfan is and is not, why it belongs to us, and what the stages and dangers of the path entail. For those who wish to go further, each chapter and the epilogue offer small, practical steps for bringing this into daily life alongside the wajibat.

PART ONE

The Call

Why travel?

The Qur’an invites more than the minimum: not only knowing about God, but knowing Him. That knowing is reached by purifying the heart, and our own prayers already ask for it.

1 · More than the minimum
2 · Knowing about God is not knowing Him
3 · You already know these words

إِلٰهِي لَمْ يَكُنْ لِي حَوْلٌ فَأَنْتَقِلَ بِهِ عَنْ مَعْصِيَتِكَ إِلاَّ فِي وَقْتٍ أَيْقَظْتَنِي لِمَحَبَّتِكَ

My Lord, I was not strong enough to move away from Your disobedience, except when You awakened me to Your love.

Munajat Sha‘baniyyah

1

More than the minimum

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَتَفَكَّرُونَ ﴿٢١﴾

There are indeed signs in that for a people who reflect.

Qur'an 30:21

At many weddings, someone recites a verse most of us know. In Surah al-Rum, God says that He created spouses for us from among ourselves "that you may take comfort in them", and that He ordained "affection and mercy" between husband and wife (Q 30:21). The verse ends with the words above: this is a sign for a people who reflect. The sign is there for everyone, yet, as with beauty, seeing it lies in the eye of the beholder. It depends on something inside the person doing the looking. That something, and why it is worth seeking above and beyond the minimum, is what this chapter sets out to explore.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *'Irfan*: knowing God from close · *ma'rifah*: knowledge of God · *'arif* (plural *'urafa'*): one who knows God · *muqarrabun*: those brought near to God · *awliya' Allah*: the friends of God · *shirk*: setting up a partner beside God

What the minimum leaves out

Let's start with what nobody disputes. A believer who prays, fasts, pays what is due, and goes on hajj can hope for *jannah*, provided they do what is *wajib* and avoid what is forbidden. Sheikh Bahmanpour accepts this as fair for ordinary believers, and Mohammad Ali Shomali adds that the obligatory rules of fiqh are "the minimally necessary conditions of human perfection"[3].

> **STORY: WHAT WAS ENOUGH FOR JANNAH**
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> Someone once came to the Prophet ﷺ and said that they had no eagerness for the night prayer (*salat al-layl*), the recommended fasts, and the like. They asked whether they would go to jannah if they prayed the five daily prayers, fasted in Ramadan, paid their zakat, and went on hajj once. The Prophet said yes. Sheikh Bahmanpour opens his first lecture with this story and draws his question from the Prophet's answer: if the obligatory acts are enough for jannah, why take on the hard work of ʿirfan?

Some jurists and activists go further, and this point of contention delineates those who reject ʿirfan from those who seek it, with this book being a guide for the latter. Those jurists' claim is that the obligatory acts make up the whole of the religion, and that anything beyond them is not grounded in evidence but in mystical fancies.

The Qur'an answers this narrow view a few lines after the wedding verse, pointing in Surah al-Rum to three further sets of signs: the creation of the heavens and the earth, with the variety of our languages and colours; our sleep and our work; and the lightning and the rain that revives the dead earth (Q 30:22–24). Like the wedding verse, each of them ends by naming the people the sign is for.

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّلْعَالِمِينَ ﴿٢٢﴾

There are indeed signs in that for those who know.

Qur'an 30:22

[3]Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 17.

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَسْمَعُونَ ﴿٢٣﴾

There are indeed signs in that for a people who listen.

Qur'an 30:23

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَعْقِلُونَ ﴿٢٤﴾

There are indeed signs in that for people who exercise their reason.

Qur'an 30:24

Four times in a row, the Qur'an makes the same point. The signs are all around us: in marriage, in the people we meet, in sleep, in work, and in the weather. Yet they are for those who reflect, know, listen, and reason. This reflecting, knowing, listening, and reasoning is what the Qur'an asks of us beyond the minimum.

For the avoidance of doubt, this invitation from the Qur'an is not an invitation to circumvent the law or to abandon the prescribed wajibat. Imam Khomeini insists that a genuine seeker's devotion "is within the bounds of the Shari'ah"[4]. Within those bounds, the Qur'an is just as insistent: it invites us to more than the obligatory acts.

Signs most people miss

An invitation addressed to those who reflect, know, listen, and reason implies that many people do none of these things. This is not limited to the careless. Most pious people, even those careful about the shari'a, do not find a sign in these verses. Looking at the variety of languages and colours, we are more likely to see a reason for division than a sign of God.

We have heard these verses many times and, as the Sheikh puts it, accept them out of obedience: "you say there are signs, so there are signs." Accepting that a sign exists is still not the same as perceiving it, and the Qur'an describes that gap in a single verse.

[4]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 61.

وَكَأَيِّن مِّنْ ءَايَةٍ فِي ٱلسَّمَٰوَٰتِ وَٱلْأَرْضِ يَمُرُّونَ عَلَيْهَا وَهُمْ عَنْهَا مُعْرِضُونَ ﴿١٠٥﴾

How many a sign there is in the heavens and the earth that they pass by while they are disregardful of it!

Qur’an 12:105

‘Allama Tabataba’i explains what passing by a sign means; a person who sees a red light thinks of the danger it warns of, not of the colour and shape of the lamp. In the same way, the things of the world are signs, and “what the signs indicate is not this world, but the person of its Creator”[5]. Most of us see only the lamp. We witness the rain as rain and the marriage as a marriage, and we pass them by without perceiving what they say about their Creator.

The fault is in the receiver

If the signs are present and plain, and yet we still pass them by, the fault is on our side. Of those who possess every faculty and yet use none of them, the Qur’an makes clear their fault.

لَهُمْ قُلُوبٌ لَّا يَفْقَهُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ أَعْيُنٌ لَّا يُبْصِرُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ ءَاذَانٌ لَّا يَسْمَعُونَ بِهَآ ۚ أُوْلَٰٓئِكَ كَٱلْأَنْعَٰمِ بَلْ هُمْ أَضَلُّ

they have hearts with which they do not understand, they have eyes with which they do not see, they have ears with which they do not hear. They are like cattle; indeed, they are more astray.

Qur’an 7:179

Cattle see and hear perfectly well, so the comparison cannot be about the senses. It is about what lies behind the senses. Eyes and ears take in the surface of things, whereas inside a human being there should be something more: a faculty, which animals lack, that turns what the senses take in into understanding. In most of us, it is not working.

Sheikh Bahmanpour compares this faculty to a machine. The ear catches the sound, but “there is something inside which doesn’t catch it. There is a machine inside which is [rusted].” That machine is the soul. It has to be

[5]Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 6–7.

repaired before it can catch the signals of God. This is the whole subject in one sentence: mysticism is about making the soul hear, see, and reflect. It is not easy, and it requires a great deal of training.

If the fault lies in the receiver, two things follow. One is that we have never lacked evidence; the signs are there, and we have failed to receive them.

The other, more hopeful, is that the problem can be solved. A faculty that exists but has rusted gives us the solace of knowing that rust can be abrased, whereas a faculty that is absent can never be made present. The *Kernel of the Kernels*, a record of ʿAllama Tabataba'i's early lectures on the path, opens by saying that the pull towards the unseen is "part of the innate instincts of the human being"[6]. The longing for God, and the faculty that perceives Him, are part of how we are made.

Repair is only the start. Once the inner faculty begins to work, a journey begins that, in the Sheikh's words, "has a beginning and no end".

Some do see

If the faculty can be repaired, there should be people in whom it already works. The Qur'an describes them in four verses. Perhaps the simplest way humans can divide themselves is also the most revealing, separating those with a working soul and those with a broken one. The first group are the *ʿurafa'* (the plural of *ʿarif*). While the prophets and the Imams (as) are a class of their own, the ʿurafa' are ordinary believers who see more than the rest. Surah al-Anfal gives the first of these descriptions.

إِنَّمَا ٱلْمُؤْمِنُونَ ٱلَّذِينَ إِذَا ذُكِرَ ٱللَّهُ وَجِلَتْ قُلُوبُهُمْ

The faithful are only those whose hearts tremble [with awe] when Allah is mentioned,

Qur'an 8:2

A heart does not dwell on what it does not know, and much less can it feel what it has not felt; only from intimate experience can a heart tremble with

[6] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 4.

true knowledge. The believers of this verse are thus the believers who know Allah. A verse in Surah Al ‘Imran goes further and gives them another name.

شَهِدَ ٱللَّهُ أَنَّهُۥ لَآ إِلَٰهَ إِلَّا هُوَ وَٱلْمَلَٰٓئِكَةُ وَأُو۟لُوا۟ ٱلْعِلْمِ

Allah ... bears witness that there is no god except Him, and [so do] the angels and those who possess knowledge.

Qur’an 3:18

For Sheikh Bahmanpour, “those who possess knowledge” is another name for the ‘urafa’. Every Muslim knows that there is no god but Allah and says so in every prayer, yet our knowledge of *tawhid*, God’s oneness, is not the knowledge of those who witness it. Tawhid is simple to say and hard to grasp, and its depths are reached by the awakened soul rather than by the intellect alone. Surah Fatir describes the same people by what they feel.

إِنَّمَا يَخْشَى ٱللَّهَ مِنْ عِبَادِهِ ٱلْعُلَمَٰٓؤُا۟

Only those of Allah’s servants having knowledge fear Him.

Qur’an 35:28

Most of us fear Allah’s punishment. The people of this verse fear Him with a fear that is not about punishment at all.

In Surah Yunus they are the *awliya’ Allah*, the friends of God (Q 10:62). Imam ‘Ali (as) describes what these friends see that others miss.

God’s special devotees are those who perceive the world’s reality when others are deceived by her appearance. They occupy themselves with what is coming when others occupy themselves with the present.[7]

Nahj al-Balagha

Where other people look at the surface of the world, the friends of God look at what lies inside it. None of this means turning away from the world. There is nothing wrong with being rich, so long as the wealth does not take up the heart, and the friends of God have families, friends, and a place in society, as we

[7] Imam ‘Ali, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 3.403.

do. Their thoughts are on God rather than on themselves, and in their hearts they are cut off from everything else.

What they are given, and why it is open to all

Of the three gifts the Qur'an names for these people, nearness comes first. Surah al-Waqi'a sorts people on the Last Day, and at the top it places the Foremost Ones.

وَٱلسَّٰبِقُونَ ٱلسَّٰبِقُونَ ﴿١٠﴾ أُوْلَٰٓئِكَ ٱلْمُقَرَّبُونَ ﴿١١﴾

And the Foremost Ones are the foremost ones: they are the ones brought near [to Allah],

Qur'an 56:10-11

The Arabic for "brought near" is *muqarrabun*. God is not far from anyone. Being brought near means that a veil between the person and God has been removed, so that they understand far more.

Surah al-Nahl promises the second, a different kind of life, to whoever acts righteously, man or woman, while having faith.

مَنْ عَمِلَ صَٰلِحًا مِّن ذَكَرٍ أَوْ أُنثَىٰ وَهُوَ مُؤْمِنٌ فَلَنُحْيِيَنَّهُۥ حَيَوٰةً طَيِّبَةً

Whoever acts righteously, [whether] male or female, should he be faithful, We shall revive him with a good life

Qur'an 16:97

This good and clean life (*hayat tayyiba*) is the life that mystics seek. Its people live in the world without being soiled by it, rising above the worries that occupy everyone else.

The third, peace, is promised in the verse of Surah Yunus that names the friends of God.

أَلَآ إِنَّ أَوْلِيَآءَ ٱللَّهِ لَا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلَا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ ﴿٦٢﴾

Look! The friends of Allah will indeed have no fear nor will they grieve

Qur’an 10:62

For the muqarrabun, who have no fear and do not grieve, the terms are entirely different from those of ordinary believers.

None of this would matter to an ordinary reader if it were reserved for prophets. Surah al-Nisa’ answers that concern.

وَمَن يُطِعِ ٱللَّهَ وَٱلرَّسُولَ فَأُوْلَٰٓئِكَ مَعَ ٱلَّذِينَ أَنْعَمَ ٱللَّهُ عَلَيْهِم مِّنَ ٱلنَّبِيِّـۧنَ وَٱلصِّدِّيقِينَ وَٱلشُّهَدَآءِ وَٱلصَّٰلِحِينَ وَحَسُنَ أُوْلَٰٓئِكَ رَفِيقًا ﴿٦٩﴾

Whoever obeys Allah and the Apostle—they are with those whom Allah has blessed, including the prophets and the truthful, the martyrs and the righteous, and excellent companions are they!

Qur’an 4:69

In this verse the Sheikh finds four ranks of those God has blessed: the prophets; the truthful (*siddiqin*); the *shuhada’*, which the translation used here renders “martyrs” and which he takes as “the witnesses”; and the righteous (*salihin*). The first three ranks are beyond us, but the fourth is a doorway. The salihin are those able to receive this favour, and from among them God chooses the truthful and the prophets. The way in is righteous action, as the verse on the good life also says.

That doorway is open to people like us. It is difficult, but we are made for it. We call ourselves human beings, yet, in the Sheikh’s words, “we are not yet human beings”: we begin with the capacity to become human in the full sense that the prophets are, and God wants us to reach it.

This is the case for pursuing ‘irfan. The Qur’an invites more than the minimum, and what stands in the way is a faculty in us that can be repaired. On the other side of that repair lie nearness to God, a good life, and freedom from fear and grief. Surah al-Nisa’ opens that rank to any believer who obeys God and the Prophet and acts righteously.

The aim is God, not powers

Pursuing ʿirfan means training the soul, and soul-training is not unique to Islam. People take up the inner life for different reasons. Some train the soul in an attempt to gain power: to be in two places at once, to see the future or the past, or to master the hidden world of the soul. Such attempts are folly and not in the spirit of a genuine pursuit of ʿirfan. Islamic mysticism is about catching the signs of Allah: becoming sensitive to them, and learning to hear and see.

Sheikh Bahmanpour ends his first lecture more strongly. ʿIrfan, he says, is not about gaining power over the soul to work the wonders of the saints (*karamat*) or the miracles of the prophets (*muʿjizat*). Such powers are *shirk*: the sin of setting up a partner beside God.

Each in their own words, the great teachers of the Shia tradition make closely related points. ʿAllama Tabataba'i tells the traveller that he "has no right to seek occult experiences and miraculous qualities", nor to perform austerities or recite invocations to gain powers such as crossing great distances in a moment or reading the thoughts of others. Whoever does so "does not move on the path of the Beloved's pleasure and his worship is not for the sake of God". It is his own self that he worships, "though he may not admit it by word of mouth"[8].

> ◈ **WHO'S WHO: ʿALLAMA TABATABA'I**
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> Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Tabataba'i is best known as the author of *al-Mizan*, a commentary on the Qur'an in twenty volumes[9]. His student Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Husayni Tihrani describes him as having flown "with the two wings of knowledge and action". He travelled the path in both philosophy and gnosis under the guidance of the gnostic Mirza ʿAli Aqa Qadi, and after years of philosophical argument he "came to settle down at the sacred threshold of the Qur'an"[10]. *Kernel of the Kernels* (*Lubb al-Lubab*) is Tihrani's record of the lectures on ethics and gnosis that Tabataba'i gave to students in Qum in 1949–50[11]. He

[8] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), pp. 28–29.
[9] Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 30.
[10] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 8.
[11] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 9.
[12] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 4.

also wrote the preface to *Light Within Me*[12], from which several quotations in this chapter come.

Imam Khomeini reports the test his teacher Ayatullah Shahabadi used: the measure of true spiritual effort is how much selfishness is in it. If a traveller's "spiritual exercises are meant for acquiring powers for worldly ends, his efforts are rendered invalid"[13].

Murtada Mutahhari echoes the Sheikh's words, again using the word *shirk*. The ʻurafa', he writes, consider it "a kind of shirk (polytheism) for one's goal in life and particularly in worship to be something other than God Himself", and he recalls Imam ʻAli (as) saying that he worshipped God not from fear of His Fire or desire for His Paradise but because he found Him worthy of worship[14].

The scholars differ in emphasis but agree that powers are not the aim. Mutahhari also explains why seeking them would be shirk: the goal has become something other than God.

Seeking, and nothing else

With powers set aside, what remains is the definition Sheikh Bahmanpour gives at the end of his first lecture: ʻirfan "is actually seeking and nothing else". It seeks the knowledge of God (*maʻrifah*) and the love of God (*mahabba*).

ع **WORD STUDY: ʻIRFAN AND MAʻRIFAH**

ʻIrfan, *maʻrifah*, *ʻarif* and its plural *ʻurafa'* belong to one family of words about knowing. An ʻarif, as Sheikh Bahmanpour puts it, is "someone who knows". "Mystic" is used of Christians, Hindus, and Buddhists alike; ʻarif is the Islamic word, and it means something more distinct. Murtada Mutahhari draws the line. The philosopher wants a correct picture of the world in his mind. The ʻarif "wishes to reach the very kernel and reality of existence, God, to become connected to it and witness it"[15]. *Lantern of the Path*, attributed to Imam al-Sadiq (as), says that there is no way to God except through knowledge[16]. What kind of knowledge that is, and how it differs from what we learn from books, is the subject of Chapter Two.

[13] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 61.
[14] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 44.
[15] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 12.
[16] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shariʻa), p. 9.

‘Irfan is therefore worth pursuing: it is the training of the soul to perceive and love God, open to every believer, and sought for God alone.

If the aim is to know and love God, what kind of knowing is that?

> **TRY THIS**
>
> Sheikh Bahmanpour builds his first lesson on the four signs of Surah al-Rum. For one week, read Q 30:21–24 slowly once a day. After each verse, ask yourself what he found in its ending: whether you reflect, whether you know, whether you listen, and whether you use your reason. Then, at some point in the day, notice one of the four signs where it occurs in your life: the affection in your home, the languages and colours of the people you meet, your own sleep and the work that earns your living, or the rain.